

says, "Our company's favourite pastimes seem to be Orkut and blogging. We blocked them, but they started using public proxy servers to get access again. As for personal blogs, we had to send out a memo telling our employees that their blogs were being monitored, and warnings were issued. Still, some people are so addicted to Orkut, Adult Friend Finder, Yahoo! 360, or blogging that they risk their jobs by trying to access them."

A business manager in a small publication house says, "We have various levels of computer users, only one of which gets Net access. The rest, designers for example, get only company e-mail access. Our problem is not Net-based, it's Windows games that waste the most time. I am sure we have at least a few *Solitaire* and *Spider* champions in our midst!"

Most of the other bosses we spoke to had the same complaints. A few were more concerned about company e-mail and what employees were e-mailing out of the company (despite confidentiality clauses), rather than what mails they were receiving. Some even related incidents of virus attacks that obviously originated from within the office, because some employee thought it would be fun to have some time off to watch system admins battle the malware.

Overall, the Sith lords of the multi-verse... err... we mean bosses, stood together and in unison cried, "Foul!"

## Smaller Solutions

Now, companies with computer strengths of more than 100 PCs are generally well-organised. They've been bitten by the time-wasting bug and have mended their ways. It's the smaller companies (at least amongst the ones we spoke to) that didn't seem to realise how much of employee productivity they were losing. An HR manager for a small services company (10 PCs) was shocked when we told her what other bosses were saying. We decided to sow the seeds of doubt in her head, installed a monitoring software on a server, enabled logging, and went back after three days. "I can't believe it, I can't believe it," she repeated, when we showed her that her 10 PCs had sent / received over 5,000 IMs in those three days. Taking an average of 10 seconds wasted per message sent / received (they have just a 256K connection), that worked out to  $5,000 \times 10 = 50,000$  seconds / 3,600 = almost 14 hours of productive time wasted. Close to 30 minutes a day per PC!

With bills to make, payments to collect, and accounts to be tallied, we're betting she's waiting for this article to see how to stop her company's PCs from being misused thusly.

"As a smaller company, we have to work doubly hard to compete with larger, richer companies. I'm certainly not going to rock the boat and ban IMs, but I will send out a memo to the employees." She thanked us for the help and says she will make sure all her employees read this article.

Enough of the reality bytes: time for some problems and their solutions...



## Unnecessary Browsing

The most common complaint we received was that employees waste time surfing. Not only is productivity affected, it's also a complete waste

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of bandwidth. Here in India, whether at home or at work, we still pay for bandwidth by the MB or GB, so any savings is always welcome.



## Proxy Server

A proxy server can do a lot more than restricting employees to certain sites. If it has a caching system, it can help cut your bandwidth costs in half. Instead of fetching the same page 10 times for 10 PCs, it does so once, and serves the same page to anyone who requests it.

Apart from bandwidth savings, a proxy server also helps you identify who's doing what, and visiting what sites, for how long a day. No, you don't have to get all worried now and think lawsuits: this is not spying, it's merely called logging. You have a right to know how your proxy server is being used.

Apart from threatening your lackadaisical employees with its logging capabilities, a proxy server can even be used to block access to sites, or even be configured to only allow access to certain sites. Another boon is the fact that you can ban many file extensions, such as .exe, .zip, .rar, etc. to prevent your employees from downloading so much. If you choose your proxy solution well enough, you can even block all IM protocols.

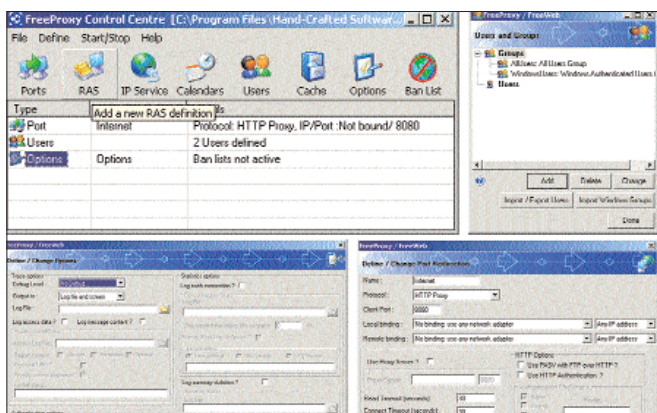


## Suggested Software

**Squid (www.squid-cache.org):** If you can spare a server PC for Linux, this is the software you should use. It supports caching (accelerated surfing), SSL, and DNS caching, is very, very scalable—whether it's 10 PCs or 10,000 accessing the Net, it's stable—and if that weren't enough, it's open source and completely free! Though it does run on Windows via emulators, you're better off running it on Linux. It's not newbie-friendly, though, so if you haven't a clue about Linux or editing configuration files, steer clear.

**FreeProxy (www.handcraftedsoftware.org):** All the features you'd want, including detailed logging, complete access control, ban lists, caching, authentication, and much more. In short, it's quite a well rounded proxy / caching / Net access restriction software, it's free, it's scalable, and runs on Windows. For smaller setups, this is a good choice because it just sits on a computer, runs as a Windows service, and will bring down bandwidth usage considerably.

**WinGate (www.wingate.com):** Medium-sized



FreeProxy is good for safeguarding small businesses from the costs associated with bandwidth wastage by employees goofing off